The History of CARE Nigeria

From a global movement born in 1945 to a country office serving millions across Nigeria

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care

What This Presentation Covers

A journey through CARE's story — globally and in Nigeria

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Who We Are

CARE is a global leader within a worldwide movement dedicated to ending poverty — known everywhere for its unshakeable commitment to the dignity of people. CARE works around the globe to save lives, defeat poverty, and achieve social justice.

OUR MISSION

CARE works around the globe to save lives, defeat poverty, and achieve social justice.

OUR VISION

A world of hope, inclusion and social justice where poverty has been overcome.

OUR FOCUS

We put women and girls in the center because we cannot overcome poverty until all people have equal rights and opportunities.

CARE Nigeria is one of the many country offices of CARE. CARE is an acronym for Cooperative for Assistance and Relief Everywhere, and is a leading humanitarian organization fighting global poverty — founded in 1945 with the creation of the CARE Package®.

Source: carenigeria.org/mission-and-vision

Our Values

Five enduring principles that guide everything CARE does

Transformation

Urgent action, innovation, and the necessity of transformation — within the world and our own organization.

Integrity

Accountable to the people and partners we humbly serve, transparently sharing our results, stories, and lessons.

Diversity

Embracing differences, including a variety of voices, and joining together to solve complex problems.

Excellence

Challenging ourselves to the highest level of learning and performance, tapping the best of the human spirit.

Equality

The equal value of every human being; change happens through people.

We believe in the equal value of every human being — and we know that change happens through people.

Global Origins: Born in 1945

In 1945, CARE — then the Cooperative for American Remittances to Europe — took possession of 2.8 million “10-in-1” military food rations known as the CARE Package®. That same year, CARE delivered its first CARE Packages to Le Havre, France, and by the end of the year had operations in 10 European nations.

1945 — the year CARE and the famous CARE Package® were born, out of World War II relief efforts. The package soon expanded to soap, textiles, toys, seed programs and self-help agricultural projects.

Over 78 years
of fighting global poverty — now in 109 countries, reaching 167 million people worldwide.

WHAT THE NAME MEANS

Founded as the Cooperative for American Remittances to Europe. As the mission grew worldwide, in 1992 the name became Cooperative for Assistance and Relief Everywhere — and the “E” became “Everywhere.”

CARE TODAY (2024)

CARE works in over 118 countries, reaching more than 53 million people through 1,450 projects — with CARE Nigeria among its country offices.

History of CARE in Nigeria

The story of CARE started in Nigeria long before the establishment of a Country Office. In 2001/2002, the Regional Office for West Africa started implementing cross-border programming in Nigeria.

27 APRIL 2017 — OFFICIAL REGISTRATION

As a result of the protracted humanitarian crisis in the northeast, CARE was officially registered in Nigeria with the Corporate Affairs Commission (CAC), and signed an MOU with the Government of Nigeria.

FIRST PROGRAMS

Program implementation focused specifically on Borno and Yobe States, with Reproductive Health and Food Security Projects.

FIRST DONORS

Our first donors were CARE USA, CARE Canada, and the World Food Programme (WFP).

BEYOND EMERGENCY RESPONSE

CARE supports longer-term efforts that strengthen resilience, improve social service systems, and influence federal and state policies.

Since 2017, we have reached over 3.1 million people with lifesaving humanitarian assistance in Food and Nutrition, WASH, Protection, Violence Against Women and Girls, and Sexual and Reproductive Health and Rights.

History of CARE in Nigeria — Growth & Impact

From Borno and Yobe, the first two states where CARE started its implementation in Nigeria, we extended our presence to Kebbi, Nasarawa, Jigawa, Bauchi, Adamawa, Kogi, Niger, and, most recently, to Oyo, Lagos, Kano, Enugu, Sokoto, and Katsina as of 2024.

CARE works in Nigeria, contributing to **saving lives, fighting poverty, and promoting social justice.**

3.1M people reached
directly with lifesaving humanitarian assistance since 2017

ASSISTANCE DELIVERED IN:

- Food and Nutrition

Source: carenigeria.org/history

CARE Comes to Nigeria: The Timeline

The story of CARE in Nigeria began long before the country office existed

2001 / 2002
Cross-Border Beginnings
The CARE Regional Office for West Africa started implementing cross-border programming in Nigeria.

1

27 April 2017
Official Registration
Registered with the Corporate Affairs Commission (CAC) and signed an MOU with the Government of Nigeria.

2

2017
First Programs
Borno and Yobe States — Reproductive Health and Food Security. First donors: CARE USA, CARE Canada, WFP.

3

2024
National Reach
Presence extended to 14 states — to Oyo, Lagos, Kano, Enugu, Sokoto and Katsina.

4

CARE began work in Nigeria in 2017 in response to the protracted humanitarian crisis in the northeast of the country.

Expansion Across Nigeria

From two states in 2017 to fourteen states in 2024

WHERE IT STARTED (2017)

- Borno State

NEXT PHASE OF GROWTH

- Kebbi

MOST RECENT — AS OF 2024

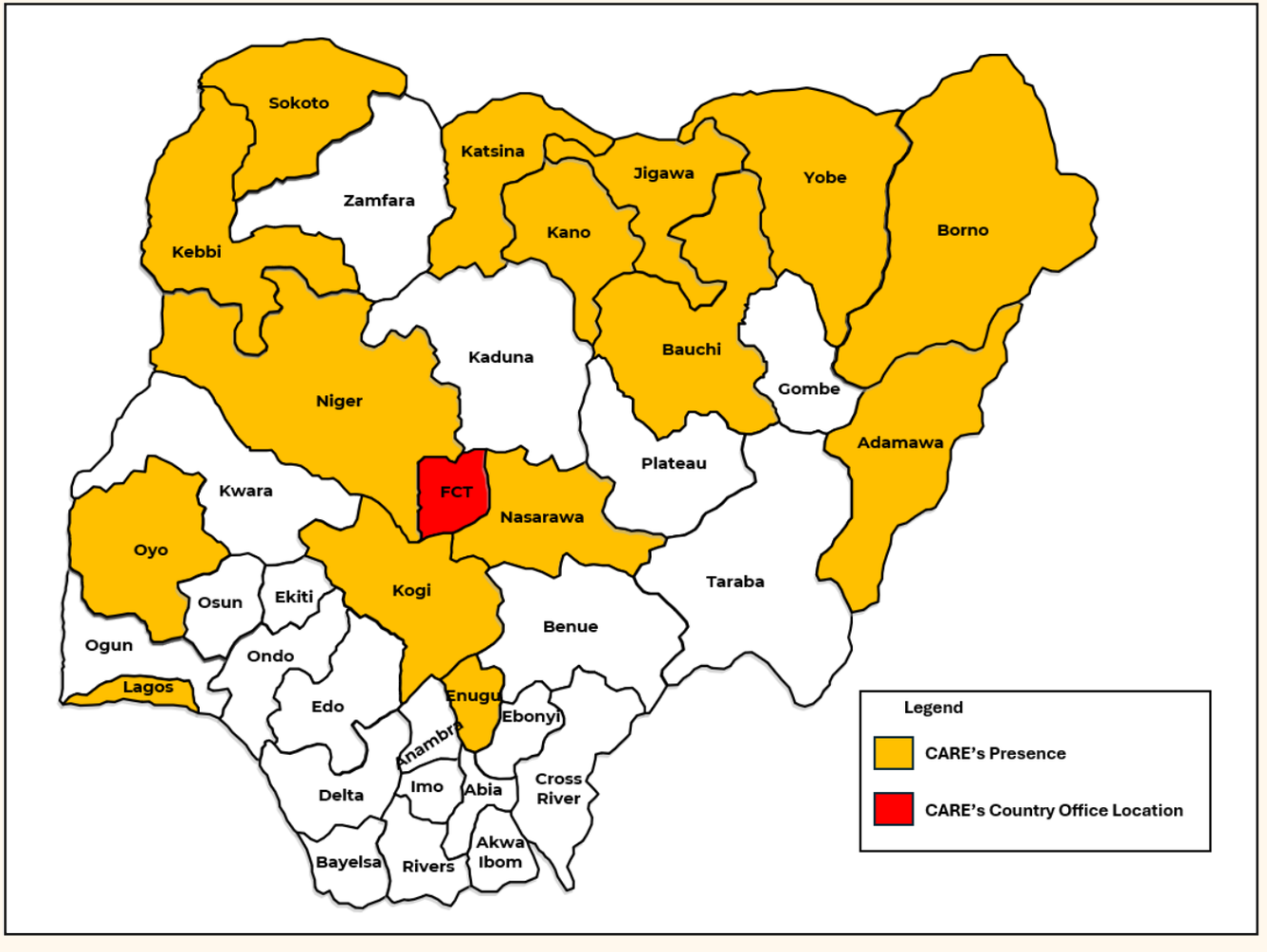
- Oyo

14 states and counting.
In 2024, CARE works in over 118 countries and reaches more than 53 million people through 1,450 projects. In Nigeria, since 2017, CARE has reached more than 3,126,834 people across 14 states.

CARE supports longer-term efforts that strengthen resilience, improve social service systems, and influence federal and state policies.

Where CARE Works in Nigeria

CARE's presence across Nigeria — 14 states and the Country Office in the FCT



IN NIGERIA, SINCE 2017

CARE has reached more than 3,126,834 people across 14 states.

GLOBALLY, IN 2024

CARE works in over 118 countries and reaches more than 53 million people through 1,450 projects.

LEGEND

- Yellow — CARE's Presence
- Red (FCT) — Country Office

Map: CARE Nigeria's Presence — carenigeria.org/history

What CARE Nigeria Does

In line with CARE's localization agenda, CARE Nigeria is working with local women-led organizations to build capacities. Our work in Nigeria focuses on:

Humanitarian Preparedness & Response

Saving lives and supporting communities affected by conflict, displacement and crisis.

Food Systems & Livelihoods

Strengthening food security and household livelihoods so families can recover and thrive.

Justice for Women and Girls

Advancing gender equality, preventing violence against women and girls, supporting survivors.

Right to Health & Nutrition

Reproductive health, rights, and nutrition programs that keep families healthy.

Since 2017, these priorities have reached over 3.1 million people with lifesaving assistance. CARE Nigeria piloted the Community of CARE and launched a national Advisory Committee to strengthen the quality, scale and impact of its programs.

Our Impact

CARE works in Nigeria, contributing to saving lives, fighting poverty, and promoting social justice.

3.1M
PEOPLE REACHED DIRECTLY
in Nigeria since 2017

67
PROJECTS
implemented across Nigeria

14 STATES

- 3,126,834 people reached since 2017

Globally, CARE works in over 118 countries, reaching more than 53 million people through 1,450 projects — and has worked to alleviate poverty for over 64 million people since its 60th anniversary in 2016.

Governance & Community

Strengthening quality, scale and impact in service to communities

THE ADVISORY COMMITTEE

CARE Nigeria launched our Advisory Committee — a pool of national experts and supporters with the key mandate to advise CARE Nigeria and its partners on matters that will strengthen and enhance the quality, scale, and impact of our development and humanitarian programs, in service to communities and families disproportionately impacted by extreme poverty and social injustice.

COMMUNITY OF CARE

We are piloting the Community of CARE, where its members shall contribute and share their expert knowledge and understanding of the Nigerian development and humanitarian sectors, policy environment, and funding landscape.

Localization in action
In line with CARE's localization agenda, CARE Nigeria is working with local women-led organizations to build capacities — ensuring Nigerian leadership drives the fight against poverty and social injustice.

The Global CARE Journey (1945 – 1975)

1945 – 1955

The Beginning: War and Recovery

CARE delivered its first CARE Packages to Le Havre, France, and by the end of the year had operations in 10 European nations. The CARE Package expanded to soap, textiles, toys, seed programs, and self-help agricultural projects. In 1950, CARE joined famine relief in Yugoslavia, Pakistan, and India, and began Korean War relief.

1956 – 1965

New Frontiers

With Europe recovering, CARE became increasingly involved in Asia and Latin America. In 1952, CARE opened its first mission in Mexico — and the “E” in CARE became “Everywhere.” CARE reached Africa (Liberia and Sierra Leone) and delivered the 50 millionth CARE Package in Colombia in 1963.

1966 – 1975

Leading Global Development

CARE transitioned to a development organization — family planning in Egypt, education programs, and war relief in Vietnam and Nigeria-Biafra. In 1967, CARE Europe formed, and the 100 millionth CARE Package was sold.

The Global CARE Journey (1976 – 2005)

1976 – 1985	1986 – 1995	1996 – 2005
New Programs: Local Leadership	**The Birth of a New CARE**	**The New Millennium**
CARE trained national staff to take over local operations. CARE International was established in 1982. Women's development programs expanded internationally. In 1983, CARE expanded rapidly in Africa, and in 1985 responded as the worst famine in a century gripped the continent.	In 1992, CARE moved its headquarters from New York to Atlanta and changed its name to “Cooperative for Assistance and Relief Everywhere.” In 1993, CARE committed to focusing on women and girls as key agents of change. In 1995, CARE celebrated its first 50 years.	Empowerment, equity, sustainability and advocacy: CARE tackled poverty's root causes and strengthened civil society through terrorism, war and the HIV/AIDS pandemic. By 2005: basic and girls' education, emergency response, HIV/AIDS, water and sanitation.

The Global CARE Journey (2006 – Present)

2006 – 2015
Women and Girls at the Center

CARE placed women and girls at the center while working alongside men and boys — Pathways to Empowerment and signature programs in maternal health, education, leadership and economic opportunity. CARE became a leading responder to food crises and droughts across the globe.

2016 – Present
Scaling the Future

CARE, an international NGO, has been working to alleviate poverty in over 64 million people since its 60th anniversary in 2016. New tools track impact globally, aligning with the Sustainable Development Goals. This is the era in which CARE Nigeria was born and grew.

CARE's understanding of poverty has grown over decades of experience — helping us to address poverty's root causes. Today, CARE and partners work in 109 countries, reaching 167 million people around the world through poverty-fighting development and humanitarian aid programs.

CARE Nigeria: born from this global journey — cross-border programming in 2001 to 14 states in 2024.

In This Section

Explore more about CARE Nigeria at carenigeria.org

History

The full story of CARE in Nigeria and CARE's global journey across eight decades.

carenigeria.org/history

Partners

The donors and partners who make CARE Nigeria's work possible — including CARE USA, CARE Canada and WFP.

carenigeria.org/partners

Team

Meet the team leading CARE Nigeria's development and humanitarian programs.

carenigeria.org/team

Vision

CARE's mission, vision, focus and values — a world of hope, inclusion and social justice.

carenigeria.org/mission-and-vision

“A world of hope, inclusion, and social justice.”

Where poverty has been overcome and all people live with dignity and security.

Sources: carenigeria.org — Mission & Vision and History